

BUILDING A LONGEVITY-READY WORKPLACE

REDESIGN CAREERS

Create phased career paths with lateral moves, advisory roles and project-based assignments

OFFER FLEXIBLE WORK

Support employees balancing caregiving responsibilities and changing health needs



PLAN RETIREMENT EARLIER

Introduce structured retirement and transition planning several years before the exit

PRESERVE INSTITUTIONAL KNOWLEDGE

Build formal mentoring and knowledge-transfer programmes before experienced employees retire

DESIGN FOR CAPABILITY, NOT AGE

Move away from age-based career expectations and focus on skills, contribution and continuous learning

Neha Sharma, Chief Human Resources Officer at Vedanta Group, says organisations, particularly in asset-intensive sectors such as mining, metals and energy, cannot afford to lose decades of operational knowledge even as they accelerate digital transformation.

“As AI, automation and digital technologies reshape industries, the real competitive advantage will not come from choosing between experience and digital talent, it will come from combining both,” she says. “For sectors like ours, decades of operational knowledge are as critical as digital capability, making multigenerational workforces a strategic advantage.”

AI may prove to be one of the first technologies that increases the value of experienced professionals rather than diminishing it, says Prof. Saravanan Kesavan, Dean at BITSom, provided they are willing to keep learning. “Earlier technologies largely favoured younger people. AI is different because it favours domain expertise. To use AI effectively, you need subject knowledge and judgement. Those are capabilities that experienced professionals typically possess in greater measure.”

The bigger risk, according to Kesavan, is not age but resistance to learning.

“If someone doesn’t want to upskill or learn AI, their career lifespan will be limited. But for people in their 40s or 50s who are willing to learn, this may be the best time ever to re-enter the workforce.”

Kesavan believes AI training must start at the top. “If CEOs and senior managers don’t understand AI, they may reject good ideas simply because they don’t understand them.

That becomes a barrier to innovation.” But he warns against neglecting younger talent, saying organisations that invest only in experienced employees risk creating a “broken ladder” with too little entry-level hiring.

In an economy where people may work well into their seventies, the question is no longer whether experience matters, but whether it continues to evolve. AI may be rewriting jobs, but it is also redefining what makes experience valuable. For professionals willing to keep learning, longevity may become less a liability than a competitive advantage. **BT**